



PHOTO BY **RAJWANT RAWAT**

in urban infrastructure. Why has India not been able to prepare and implement such plans?

See, our bureaucrats are brilliant. But can you expect a person to become a visionary in three years of posting, however bright he might be? It takes decades. So, for instance, we have to bring in domain experts. As our economy grows, further strain will come on infrastructure.

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It is a matter of concern and we must bring in radical changes.

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How do you see the future of the market?

India is poised to become the third-largest economy in the next four years, after the US and China. As the economy grows further, in a democracy like India, demand for homes, schools, and other such infrastructure will continue to grow, resulting in a much larger housing market than what it is today.

But the question remains on affordability. The purchasing power of people has to increase. Today, that power is confined to the high-income group families. But it has to percolate down.

Housing is not a luxury but a part of the basic needs. A section of the society needs housing along with growing purchasing power to meet the prices. That will be a key challenge for any future government. The question is not about future prosperity at the top but growing the incomes of the lower strata.

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In this highly successful career, what do you consider as your greatest achievement?

To be able to win over the confidence of the farmers and to be able to buy 1,000 acres of

land [to build modern Gurugram]. It took me over a decade as the land was fragmented among hundreds of them with each holding a few acres.

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What has been the most challenging period in your career?

It was when an arrest warrant was issued on my name. I was being chased by the police. But that is also the period when I laid the foundation of DLF Phase 5, which is the heart of DLF Gurgaon.

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How do you envision DLF's future outside Gurugram, in other parts of India? Should it venture into key overseas markets?

There is always an opportunity to grow, everywhere. But if one tries to bite more than his capacity to chew, indigestion is bound to happen. DLF has been limited by this, I often witness overseas companies being unproductive and, I think, if DLF ventures into such markets it will do very well. However, how many places can we be at once? Our policy is to take up a job and do it well. So, we have to take one step at a time and not try to run here and there. And that will take time. **BT**

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